

“Why is it scanning all my stuff”: analysing how gamers negotiate trust in data-driven moderation systems

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Anti-cheat surveillance reaches into the device itself

- Online games are sites of **intimate sociotechnical governance** — players submit to invasive systems to access play.
- Riot's **Vanguard** (Valorant 2020; League of Legends 2024) is an example of surveillance at **kernel level**, triggering sustained backlash.
- Algorithmic moderation scholarship has grown, but **gaming related systems enforcement** remain largely uncharted (Kerr et al. 2014).
- Little empirical evidence on how players **perceive, evaluate and respond** to invasive governance in online gaming (Bourdoucen et al. 2023).



Studying trust as relational vulnerability across nested scales

↔ Relational trust

Negotiating expected vulnerabilities and connectedness in relationships (Baier 1986; Scheman 2020)

🌐 Complex ecologies of trust

Dynamic evaluation across micro, meso, and macro risks exposed to (Steedman et al. 2020)

How do gamers negotiate invasive governance?

- **RQ1** — What elements of **vulnerability** do players identify in Vanguard?
- **RQ2** — Through which **constructs** is Riot's trustworthiness evaluated?
- **RQ3** — Across which **actors and scales** does that evaluation operate?

Reddit discourse around a moment of rupture

Design

Qualitative discourse analysis of community sensemaking around an algorithmic artefact; Vanguard treated as a rupture making power visible.

Corpus

Three subreddits (r/leagueoflegends 8.3M, r/VALORANT 2.6M, r/riotgames 42K); 2020–2025; keywords: anti-cheat, vanguard, privacy.

Keyword search across
3 subreddits → 2,550
posts



Dedup & relevance
screening → 804 posts



TF-IDF expansion of
keywords → 605 posts
+ 5,561 threads



Explorative + deductive
coding in OpenQDA to
saturation

RQ1: Vulnerabilities are felt at the intimate computing layer

- Players frame kernel access as **qualitatively different** from ordinary permissions.
- Read as a **violation of the intimate boundary** between player and device.
- Continuous scanning persists **outside gameplay**, integrating machines into networked monitoring.
- Players describe Vanguard less as a game feature than as an **always-on observer** embedded in personal hardware.



Kernel access Most salient element: deepest level of OS observation



Continuous scanning Devices integrated into a wider surveilled network, exposed to cybercrime



Material harm Reported system interruptions and, in some cases, hardware damage

RQ2: Trustworthiness rests on four negotiated dimensions

Reliability

Does Riot consistently manage its software overall responsibly?

Competence

Can the developer build and maintain the anti-cheat safely?

Honesty

Are public-facing communications by Riot and its employees truthful or just PR?

Necessity

Is the invasiveness genuinely proportionate to the threat?

RQ3: Trust evaluation spans micro, meso and macro scales



Micro

Personal device incidents and 'us vs them' communal identity anchor distrust.



Meso

Riot employees' statements scrutinised; third-party software framed as vectors of risk.



Macro

State surveillance, Tencent ownership, organised cybercrime — sharper in LoL than Valorant.



Datafication governance from below

- Players cannot opt out without losing access (Bernevega & Gekker 2021) yet are **cognitively and socially active**.
- Informal evaluative frameworks **hold developers accountable** via public discourse.
- Community functions as **mutual support** (Maris et al. 2025) and collective sensemaking space (DeVito et al. 2016).
- Herein, macro scale is not background but an **active ingredient** in micro-level trust negotiations.
- Findings limited by Reddit's skew **vocal, technically literate, English-speaking** players.

✓ **Conclusions**

- Anti-cheat is a **consequential, undertheorised** modality of algorithmic platform governance (Kerr et al. 2014).
- Trust hinges on reliability, competence, honesty **and necessity** — a proportionality around who decides the conditions of play (Consalvo, 2007).
- Players perform a **multi-scalar audit** linking micro scales from personal device intimacy to macro issues of geopolitics and cybercrime.
- Next: cross-community comparison and deeper actor-network mapping.

Thank you

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